bleeding-edge version of your application. This kind of transparency is a great way to ensure that your project isn't going off the tracks.

Editors

We write our Rails programs using a programmer's editor. We've found over the years that different editors work best with different languages and environments. For example, Dave originally wrote this chapter using Emacs because he thinks that its Filladapt mode is unsurpassed when it comes to neatly formatting XML as he types. Sam updated the chapter using Vim. But many think that neither Emacs nor Vim is ideal for Rails development. Although the choice of editor is a personal one, here are some suggestions for features to look for in a Rails editor:

- Support for syntax highlighting of Ruby and HTML—ideally, support for `erb` files (a Rails file format that embeds Ruby snippets within HTML).

- Support for automatic indentation and reindentation of Ruby source. This is more than an aesthetic feature: having an editor indent your program as you type is the best way to spot bad nesting in your code. Being able to reindent is important when you refactor your code and move stuff. (TextMate's ability to reindent when it pastes code from the clipboard is convenient.)

- Support for insertion of common Ruby and Rails constructs. You'll be writing lots of short methods, and if the IDE creates method skeletons with a keystroke or two, you can concentrate on the interesting stuff inside.

- Good file navigation. As you'll see, Rails applications are spread across many files; for example, a newly created Rails application enters the world containing seventy-seven files spread across forty-five directories. That's before you've written a thing.

  You need an environment that helps you navigate quickly among these. You'll add a line to a controller to load a value, switch to the view to add a line to display it, and then switch to the test to verify you did it all right. Something like Notepad, where you traverse a File Open dialog box to select each file to edit, won't cut it. We prefer a combination of a tree view